

Berkeley, Dialogue I

Jan 13, 2004

Sensible objects

- Sensible objects are the things we perceive *immediately*.
- An object is perceived *immediately* if it is perceived 'without the intervention of others'.
 - If *reasoning* or *inference* is required for a person to get to think about something, that thing is not immediately perceived.

For instance, when I hear a coach drive along the streets, immediately I perceive only the sound; but from the experience I have had that such a sound is connected with a coach, I am said to hear the coach. It is nevertheless evident, that in truth and strictness, nothing can be *heard* but *sound*: and the coach is not then properly perceived by sense, but suggested from experience... In short, those things alone are actually and strictly perceived by any sense, which would have been perceived, in case that same sense had then been first conferred on us. (p.90 / 204)

- Is it true that we wouldn't perceive the coach without appropriate past experience?

Sensible qualities

- We don't immediately perceive by the senses anything except the sensible qualities: light, colours, figures, sounds, odours, heat and cold...
- 'Sensible things therefore are nothing else but so many sensible qualities, or combinations of sensible qualities.'
- Question: do any sensible things have an existence 'exterior to the mind, and distinct from their being perceived', as they would have to if they were material objects.

Arguments from variation

- An argument-pattern that occurs again and again:
 - hot and cold hands in the same vessel of water (66/179)
 - ‘that which at other times seems sweet, shall to a distempered palate appear bitter’ (68/180)
 - The argument from microscopes / different degrees of sharpness of vision... (71-72/184-185)
 - Vision of a mite (75/188)
 - Effects of distance (76/189)
 - Differences in ‘speed of thought’ (77/190)

Hylas: 'Whatever degree of heat we perceive by sense, we may be sure the same exists in the object that occasions it' (the *infallibility claim*) (63/175)...

Philonous: Suppose now one of your hands hot, and the other cold, and that they are both at once put into the same vessel of water, in an intermediate state; will not the water seem cold to one hand, and warm to the other?

Hylas: It will.

Philonous: Ought we not therefore by your principles to conclude, it is really both cold and warm at the same time...? (66/179)

- What happens if we give up the infallibility claim?
 - What sorts of things are immediately perceived by someone whose senses aren't working properly?
 - Berkeley: sensations.
- Berkeley has a couple of arguments that are supposed to come into play after the infallibility claim is given up.
- Let's do some 'rational reconstruction'.

A representative case: Suppose x, an ordinary healthy person, and y, a person who has “jaundice”, are both looking at a blank sheet of paper. The paper seems white to x and yellow to y.

Here are three claims Berkeley would want to make about this case:

Claim 1: x and y are immediately perceiving different things.

Claim 2: The things x and y are immediately perceiving are sensations (ideas).

Claim 3: If these sensations are both caused by a material object, the material object in question must be colorless.

Claim 1: x and y are immediately perceiving different things.

- A possible argument for this claim:
 1. x is immediately perceiving something white, and is not immediately perceiving anything yellow.
 2. y is immediately perceiving something yellow and is not immediately perceiving anything white.
 3. Therefore, there is nothing that both x and y are immediately perceiving.

- Where does Berkeley get the premises of this argument (in particular the second)?
 - Perhaps we could appeal here to Berkeley's definition of immediate perception as perception that is independent of reason and past experience (p. 90). Things we perceive immediately are things whose sensible properties we can come to know without having to make any inferences based on past experience. But plainly y *does* need past experience to know that anything in the situation is white!

Claim 2: The things x and y are immediately perceiving are sensations.

- At least one of the things immediately perceived by x and y is a sensation.
 - There aren't both white and yellow material objects to be seen; and the only other candidates are sensations.
- But it would be arbitrary to suppose that x (for example) gets to immediately perceive a material object, while y only gets to immediately perceive a sensation.

Claim 3: If these sensations are both caused by a material object, the material object in question must be colorless.

- Argument 1: it would be arbitrary to suppose that some lucky perceivers get to immediately perceive sensations that are the same color as the material objects that cause them.
- Argument 2: ‘can any thing be like a sensation or idea, but another sensation or idea?’ (p. 92/206) Berkeley says: No. (This argument would also work for Claim 2.)

Criticising the argument

- It seems bizarre to think that a sensation could be *seen* [perceived], or that a sensation could be *yellow*.
 - We would normally say that sensations are *had*, not perceived; and while we might speak of a sensation ‘*of yellow*’ or ‘*of yellowness*’, that’s not the same as a sensation that is *itself* yellow.
- If we are moved by this thought, we should deny Berkeley’s claim that the jaundiced person is immediately seeing something yellow.

- If ‘immediately seen’ means ‘seen, and not by seeing anything else’, we should say that even the jaundiced person immediately sees the piece of paper.
 - If it means ‘seen in such a way that one need not rely on past experience to know its sensible qualities’, we should deny that the jaundiced person immediately sees *anything*.
- Nevertheless, we can still make a distinction between *veridical perception* (in which things seem the way they are) and *illusion*.
 - So we still have to contend with the argument from arbitrariness.